effectively cut off, preventing the sending of money or other Bolshevik agents into the country. Nevertheless, more effort could have been made to provide Bravin with credentials. There was, for example, a Persian representative in Moscow at this time, Assad Bahador, who could have pressed upon Tehran a Bolshevik desire to have Bravin recognised. Instead, Assad noted specifically in his reports home that the Bolsheviks 'have not asked for recognition for this person'.[54] Such neglect of Bravin was therefore probably also due to the lack of importance the Soviet regime placed on affairs in Persia at this time. Not only was the civil war occupying much attention but the Bolsheviks were still confused as to what role official diplomacy was to play in its foreign policy. Trotsky had, after all, upon assuming control of the Foreign Office in 1917 declared that he would 'issue some revolutionary proclamations to the peoples and close up the joint'.[55] Such ambivalence towards the traditional channels of international relations was further compounded by the dilemma the Bolsheviks faced in deciding what groups of Persians they should be working with in the first place: should support be given to nationalist and pan-Islamic revolutionary forces, or should these, essentially bourgeois movements, be discouraged in favour of truly communist organisations?[56] While Bravin may have been busy making connections with various Persian malcontents, not until 1920 would this issue be officially worked out.[57] Not until 1921, either, would the Bolshevik regime invest greater resources in their diplomatic endeavours; in the meantime, Bravin was left to his own devices.[58]

Together with Bravin's impotence, there was also reason to doubt that Communism would find fertile ground in southern Asia. In December 1918, the Persian minister, Samad Khan, stated his belief that Bolshevism would never take root in Persia, as the people were not of that militant attitude. Nevertheless the Persian government was suspicious of Bolshevism and, as Cox himself had admitted, the shah was said to be very anti-Bolshevik.[59] In any case, even if Bolshevism was the threat to Persia which Cox argued it was, Lancelot Oliphant of the Foreign Office noted that 'it is open to doubt whether the present sense of feeling here [Britain] or elsewhere would sanction our saving Persia from Bolshevism by military measures'.[60]